Yahoo! embraces anti-spyware

This could be a great boost to efforts of plugging Internet security holes: Yahoo! has decided to integrate software into its toolbar that will detect spyware and malicious files or code.

The new Yahoo! toolbar was released on 27 May, 2004—though in a test stage. Yahoo! will evaluate user responses to the technology, developed by anti-spyware company PestPatrol. It offered the toolbar as an upgrade to select users at ***http://beta.toolbar. yahoo.com.***

The software performs a high-level scan of a user's system to detect viruses and other malicious code used to spy on computer behaviour. This step comes after Yahoo! proposed the use of Bayesian filters to check spam.

Yahoo! isn't alone; Internet Service provider EarthLink recently introduced anti-spyware technology for its subscribers. Last month, Google appealed to software programmers to use clear-cut methods to distinguish software that were meant to be embedded in a user's PC.

They pushed for standardised rules for such programmes, and stated that they should contain features that would make them identifiable, provide the user freedom to uninstall them, and above all, ensure that they do not leak personal information.

A big round of applause for all companies involved in anti-spyware programmes! We all want our privacy, and finally someone is doing something to protect us from the big bad Internet

Lapping up secrets

Your laptop makes you look smug and professional, but it can also ruin you or your company if you aren't careful.

As part of a study, Pointsec Mobile Technologies—a Stockholm-based mobile security specialist firm—bought 100 laptops at Internet public auctions in Stockholm. It set a technology team to work on them, and was able to recover sensitive data from 70 of them. This sensitive data included pension plans, payroll records and even administration passwords for Intranet sites.

It was obvious that the hard drives weren't wiped clean, though companies usually do that before auctioning old machines.

The company had similar results in tests run in the US, Germany and Sweden. They claim that a laptop from a Swedish auction had all the necessary data needed to blackmail a large food manufacturer.

"Pointsec's research demonstrates just how easy it is to access information which is not adequately protected," said Tony Neate from Britain's National Hi-Tech Crime Squad, in an interview to Reuters.

Room-temperature nanotransistors

A significant stride forward in nanotechnology! A team of German and US scientists have created a single-electron transistor with a gold-tipped, vibrating silicon arm, which is 200 nanometers long and a few tens of nanometers across. The device is of special interest to theoretical physicists for quite a few reasons. Firstly, it is fairly easy to manufacture. Second, it can operate on AC voltage. Third, it operates without cryogenic cooling—which can only be achieved under special conditions using liquid Nitrogen at very low temperatures.

The device was created by Dominik Scheible at the Ludwig-Maximilians University in Munich, and Robert Blick at the University of Wisconsin-Madison. They set it up so that the gold tip of the arm sits between two electrodes-such systems, typically, operate in strong magnetic fields.

This breakthrough puts to rest the fears that a report by the European Commission created, about nanotechnology research lagging in the continent due to lack of funding. Perhaps this will finally get the Euros flooding in!

Spam

Zombie PCs relay the most spam

A study by Sandvine, a network management firm, cross referenced with SenderBase Email Reputation Service, says that more than 80 per cent of spam originates from unsuspecting systems infected with Trojan horses or worms. Popular backdoor worms that accomplish this are Migmaf and SoBig. Sandvine's technology traced home networks which were bypassing their home e-mail servers and using multiple foreign mail servers within a short span of time, thereby indicating infection.

The study says the recent wide-angled flood attacks of MyDoom and Bagle were aimed at installing spamming Trojans on home computers.

No-No to 'Do-Not-Spam'

The US Federal Trade Commission (FTC) recently submitted a report against the 'Do not e-mail' registry creation proposal. This registry was intended for spammers to stay clear of e-mail domains of certain participating members. The FTC opposes the list since it feels that the list will, in fact, be used by spammers to get hold of new e-mail domains and IDs.

snapshot

1 in 20 Britons plans to get his or her next tech gadget by insurance fraud

Source: silicon.com, April 2004

■ Seagate launches 0.5 TB enterprise hard drive ■ Intel announces six new 775-pin Pentium 4 processors—from 2.8 GHz to 3.4 GHz EE